By the end of 1568, Akbar had gathered an army together to march on Ranthambore, which was held by Surjan, the chieftain of the Hada clan. Travelling via Delhi to visit Nizamuddin Auliya's dargah, and Humayun's tomb, Akbar organized a qumargha near Palam, outside Delhi. Hunting was a supremely effective way of moving large numbers of soldiers and weapons without warning, to be able to quell resistance when required. Quite often no actual confrontation was ever required, potential troublemakers growing more circumspect in the face of these great hunting parties and their casual display of power.

Akbar arrived at Ranthambore in December 1568 and encircled and besieged the fort with ominous precision. A siege tower was constructed under Raja Todar Mal's supervision and huge mortars were dragged up the hill by 200 pairs of oxen. One particularly fearsome cannon required 1,000 oxen and several elephants to drag it uphill, and was 'reported to launch a payload of over 3000 pounds'. The Mughal guns started pounding the walls of Ranthambore but resistance, this time, was much less determined. Intimidation was clearly as effective as actual warfare and the absolute terror created by the sight of these monstrous cannons was dramatic. In less than two months, Surjan Hada sent his sons, Bhoj and Doda, to serve at Akbar's court and handed over the silver and gold keys to the fortress. In addition to the sobering effect of the calamitous fate of Chittor, Surjan Hada would have been reassured by the presence, in the Mughal army, of two Kachhwaha neighbours, Raja Bhagwant Das and Kuar Man Singh, both now respected Mughal officers. The relatively easy capture of Ranthambore after the violence of Chittor was recognized later by the Mughals as a moment of reckoning. There would be a very fine miniature painted of the submission of Surjan Hada in the *Akbarnama*. The painting is full of compassion for the chieftain, who bows before the young Padshah while Akbar gently puts his hand on his vanquished foe. A contemporary Sanskrit text, the *Surjancarita*, presents an alternate reality. According to this text Akbar was so impressed by Surjan's courage that he gifted him three territories in lieu of Ranthambore—nimbly converting defeat into victory.

The capture of the great fortresses of Chittor and Ranthambore would fundamentally alter the shape of the Mughal Empire. Until these two strongholds fell, only the relatively minor Kachhwahas and the Rathores of Merta, a junior branch of the Rathores of Jodhpur, had aligned themselves with the Mughals. But now for Akbar there would be a novel means of